

ROLE FULFILLMENT AS A MEASURE OF ARGUMENT QUALITY: LESSONS FROM BRITISH PARLIAMENTARY DEBATE

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Recently, Robert Rowland (2013) urged restraint from those of us seeking to compare the quality of US presidential debates to an ideal form of argumentative exchange, or even competitive academic debate, which at times can be far from any ideal. He said that our tests of argumentative quality “have to be reasonably adapted to the constraints of modern presidential campaigning” (p. 531). The format of presidential debates is not designed to produce substantive clash that informs the audience about the topic at hand. They are designed to serve the political interests of the candidates, and our analysis of them must take that into account. Indubitably, argumentation scholars should be sensitive to the impact of forum rules and conventions when theorizing debates within context. So too should those training their eyes on British Parliamentary [BP] debate pay close attention to the ways its unique rules and conventions frame the argumentation that occurs there.

There are a number of features that distinguish competitive BP debate from the other popular formats in the United States. Perhaps the most impactful one is the use of a ranking system for assessing teams, as opposed to awarding wins and losses. BP’s approach to adjudication goes beyond a binary “win/loss” ballot, and asks critics to weigh the overall performance of

debate teams against one another. This holistic metric includes, among other things, the quality of the insight into the topic produced by the debaters as a judging criteria.

The illustrative capacity of clash in competitive debate is often invoked as warrant for deploying it in public forums, especially when complex questions are under scrutiny (Freeley and Steinberg, 2014; Mitchell and Paroske, 2000). That same potential of debate for topic development is certainly implied as a reason for the time and resources dedicated to the enterprise by universities across the globe. BP is unique among major competitive debate formats in putting this question before critics directly in the guise of “role fulfillment” as an evaluative criterion. Exploring that subject, then, would seem to be at the heart of this timely forum.

In this essay, I first discuss the alternative models driving the major forms of competitive debate in the United States, and the implications of those models for understanding the relationship between topic exploration and the success of the debaters. I then use BP’s concept of role fulfillment to examine two threads within the scholarly literature on argumentation and debate over the past several years, the development of strategic maneuvering and proposals for invitational debate. I finally tease out implications of role fulfillment as a measure of debate performance for our understanding of argument quality overall.

Parliamentary and Judicial Models for Deliberation

For those accustomed to zero-sum, win-loss, binary outcome debate pedagogies, sussing out role fulfillment requires understanding the alternative model of deliberation that lies at the heart of this form of parliamentary debate. Johnson (2009) explained the legislative roots of BP in European parliaments, where

coalitions between different parties form a collective government and work together. Nonetheless, these coalition partners still compete with one another for public approval. Members of rival parties may come down on the same side of a proposal, but do so for different reasons, and defend their alternative views before their constituents. The outcome itself may be less important than the reasons that one has to support or oppose that outcome. BP debate embodies this model by having multiple teams use contrasting arguments on the same side of the motion.

Johnson contrasted the BP coalitional model with a judicial approach that is the foundation of binary debate formats in the United States.¹ There, argumentative strategy is focused directly toward a zero-sum, up or down vote by decision makers. In a criminal courtroom, lawyers direct arguments toward judge or jury to secure a vote of guilt or innocence. Other legal proceedings ask for their own kinds of judgments from the court (remedies for torts, appeals, injunctions, and so on). There are exceptions to either/or kinds of outcomes in courts to be sure, such as statutory or constitutional interpretation where decisions can be more open-ended. But as a metaphor for deliberation, advocates competing for a binary outcome typifies a judicial approach to argumentation. A debate format that features two teams on opposite sides of the resolution, both seeking a single victory, mirrors courtrooms in this way.

Both the judicial and the parliamentary model imply certain norms for advocates operating within them.

1 Including formats offered by the National Parliamentary Debate Association, National Debate Tournament, Cross Examination Debate Association, National Forensic Association Lincoln-Douglas Debate, International Parliamentary Debate Association, and others.

Lawyers in the judicial model are expected to vigorously attempt to win the trial or case, but there are ethical limits on the tactics that should be used. The Model Rules for Professional Conduct from the American Bar Association (2013) detailed many, such as telling the truth, not contacting jurors outside of the courtroom, or holding conflicts of interest. Courtrooms also have a judge who determines the permissibility of arguments made by lawyers through motions introduced by opposing counsel. These ethical constraints and the presence of judicial referees who can overrule certain argumentative tactics set limits on how lawyers may try to win the case. But within these parameters, lawyers are supposed to do whatever it takes to prevail in the case before them.

That is not necessarily so in a coalition based, parliamentary model of deliberation. True, any resolution before the legislative body features a binary vote. But unlike a trial that dissolves once the matter before it is adjudicated, a parliamentary coalition lives beyond any one motion. Coalition partners may win the vote on a certain provision, but do so in a manner that poisons future compromise with other legislators. Parliamentary maneuvering, straight party-line votes that provide limited opportunities for minority input, or even deceptive language smuggled into bills throughout the process are factors that can secure a binary victory (a bill might pass) but foul the comity necessary to facilitate future compromise. In the long run, winning one particular issue may turn into an overall loss of the advocate's ability to effectively argue on subsequent motions. We judge a legislator not only by whether her preferred policy prevailed, but whether she argued for that outcome within the norms of the institution and our standards of statecraft. Through elections, lawmakers are subsequently held accountable for

how they argue. While in judicial deliberations rules are enforced through motions that ensure lawyers act equitably, in a parliamentary deliberation it is the preservation of the coalition itself that incentivizes fair play.

There are parallels to the way competitive debating is structured. In binary outcome debate formats, norms are enforced through procedural arguments in the round, which are the analog of lawyer's motions. If a rival debate team is attempting to win the round in a way that is unfair or unethical, debaters can ask the judge to assign that team a loss. BP does not (at the moment) feature such explicit motions. Instead, these norms of argumentation are captured in the role fulfillment part of the BP judging paradigm. Each team has a role it is expected to perform in the debate. The two opening teams lay out the major issues implied by the topic. For the opening government, this involves defining terms and proposing a case model that facilitates robust debate throughout the round. The opening opposition team is likewise expected to outline the parameters of the case against the topic. The latter two debate teams in a BP round have a different set of roles. These include extension (bringing new material to the round) and summary in the final two rebuttal, or whip, speeches. Allowing teams in the second half of the debate to simply refute the arguments that had been made before would present a competitive imbalance in preparation time. In BP, these roles ensure fairness between teams the same way that procedural arguments do in binary debate formats.

However, there is a second reason why these particular roles are enforced in BP debate. Role fulfillment is also designed to produce a diverse and deep interrogation of the topic in the round. Johnson (2009) described this as the "better debate"

standard for argument evaluation, namely “which team contributed most to (or detracted most from) the quality of this debate?” (p. 240). He offered four criteria for determining debate quality under this standard; Inquiry (did the debaters select the most important issues)—Advancement (did they develop these issues through substantive argumentation)—Focus (did the debaters avoid tangential or non-germane issues)—Performance (did they speak well).

This “better debate” standard is not codified, even as Johnson rightly noted that most BP critics adhere to it. Adjudication cores for major BP tournaments take great pains to note that role fulfillment is not a formal rule. The adjudication team for the 2012 World Universities Debating Championship [WUDC] in Manila admonished that “role fulfillment is **not a metric to judge debates**. If you do so, you’ll get it wrong. Just judge the arguments” (De La Salle-San Miguel Corporation, 2011, p. 4, emphasis in original). The 2013 WUDC in Berlin featured a briefing explicitly noting that role fulfillment is only a characterization of the milieu of the round. “We define the aim of each team to **persuade** the judges to affirm or reject the motion. Role fulfillment, then, is **the context in which that persuasion must take place**, the boundaries that allow each team a fair chance to persuade the judges” (World Universities Debating Championship Berlin, 2013, p. 2, emphasis in original). The most explicit set of debating guidelines from an adjudication core to date came from the 2015 WUDC briefing in Kuala Lumpur. We see again the distinction between role fulfillment as a rule and role fulfillment as an expression of quality argumentation. “It is not a role fulfillment requirement for the Deputy Prime Minister or Deputy Opposition Leader to add new material . . . to the debate . . . this is not breaking the rules, and judges should not punish

teams for doing this in and of itself. But such a strategy is generally very inadvisable" (World Universities Debating Championship, 2014, p. 22, emphasis in original).

At one level, this is a distinction without a difference. Either because it is against the rules, or because it is "very inadvisable" persuasion, critics will penalize a team that fails to fulfill its role. But the distinction carries meaning when we recognize in a coalition model of deliberation there is no entity with the authority to enforce rule violations through unilateral punishment. Judicial model forums allow a judge to dismiss a case in court if rules are violated (or even jail those who break those rules). A debate critic is supposed to assign a loss in a binary format debate round if one team violates standards of equity as well. However, there are many argumentative contexts that do not have this judicial referee. The moderator of a presidential debate does not assign a loss, either because one candidate argued poorly or even if one candidate violates rules such as time limitations or speaking order. The 2016 Republican primary debates routinely featured exasperated moderators urging candidates to follow the rules that they had agreed to, but there was no mechanism for actually enforcing those rules. Judgments about performance in a presidential debate are instead made collectively by the public, through discussions about a myriad of qualities voters are looking for in their preferred candidate. As stated earlier, legislative argumentation also features multiple audiences with no unilateral authority, as well as short term and long term horizons for success. A presidential candidate or a member of parliament cannot be assigned a loss, but they can lose favor in the eyes of observers for failing to adhere to whatever "better debating" standard an audience is applying at

the time. Role fulfillment in BP works the same way; not as a rule that is violated, but as a set of conventions that are not met.

This all makes BP debate rounds different from binary format rounds in one major respect. Students must argue within the constraints of their roles. They have a commitment not just to winning an argument, but to doing so in a way that harmonizes with the other arguments on their side of the bench. BP debate in this sense is a more communal approach to argumentation, as advocates have a responsibility to support others in the round, even as they distinguish themselves from the coalition partners. BP's communalism can be contrasted with a certain ego-centrism in binary format debates, as the individual pursuit of the victory is the primary goal of the round. There are rare occasions when a binary format debate team will forfeit a round in order to, for example, spark discussion about a non-topical subject. Much more common, though, are attempts to bring in such material and *be awarded a victory for doing so*. The end pursuit of a zero-sum victory is what makes these types of formats fundamentally ego-centric.

Role fulfillment, then, serves two purposes in a coalition model debate. It polices fairness in the same way that procedural arguments that ask debate critics to vote against a rival team do in binary formats. It also injects values of inquiry and focused topic development in a way other formats do not. One can earn a victory without holding to Johnson's better debate standard in most debate formats in the United States. Debaters are not rewarded or punished for how the issues they select illuminate the topic or aid audience decision making. Perhaps it is not a coincidence that US binary formats often neglect the performance elements of the better debating standard as well. Not so in BP debate, which dwarfs US judicial debate formats in global

participation. Both of these models, though, are the foundation of public argumentation contexts as well. Armed with this distinction, we can now reconsider two threads in the argumentation literature.

Role Fulfillment and Argumentation Scholarship

First, recent decades have seen significant progress by those operating under the banner of pragma-dialectics in laying out standards for reasonableness in argumentation. The cornerstone of that movement is the belief that arguers have a normative commitment to reasonability. The meaning of reasonability in that approach has been augmented by the introduction of strategic maneuvering, which takes into account that there are specific contexts where argumentation occurs. Our perceptions of reasonableness need to recognize the latitude interlocutors have when faced by the options these contexts create. One can utilize multiple strategies of argumentation depending on audience, forum and personal goals. Strategic maneuvering asks pragma-dialecticians to consider the relationship between the strategic selection of arguments to address certain audiences and ends with the general dialectical commitment to rationality. This is “the continual effort going on in argumentative discourse to maintain the balance between aiming for rhetorical effectiveness and dialectical reasonableness” (van Eemeren, 2010, p. 11).

Case studies in strategic maneuvering help explain this balance between rhetorical and dialectical aims. Feteris (2008) described a judge who serves two competing principles in statutory interpretation. One is to remain faithful to the text of the law. The other is to avoid unreasonable or absurd outcomes from strictly interpreting that law in a given case. The judge must make a strategic decision of whether to use a tight or a loose approach to interpreting the statute, and must

further justify that decision rhetorically. After all, a judge who appears fickle will damage her reputation; there are more things to consider than merely dialectical reasonability. “From a pragma-dialectical perspective the question rises how a judge can meet his dialectical burden of proof that is consistent with this legal burden of justification and how he can manoeuvre [*sic*] strategically by also living up to his rhetorical aspirations to present the decision in such a way that his own interests are served best and that the decision is convincing for the legal audience” (Feteris, 2008, p. 337).

Iețcu-Fairclough (2008) gave another mixed mode example. Romanian President Traian Băusescu was suspended from Parliament in response to his efforts to root out political corruption. His impeachment was put before the voters in a referendum, and Băusescu had to appeal to a “heterogeneous public, made up of ‘reasonable’ and ‘unreasonable’ critics” (2008, p. 414) in defending his Presidency. Iețcu-Fairclough argued that examining his arguments requires an appreciation for the way the public will consider the implications of the outcome of the debate, in this case the fate of the controversial anti-corruption reforms. Voters do not look only at reasonability, but at the power dynamics within the government when analyzing arguments. In yet another example, Mohammed showed how the rules and conventions of Prime Minister’s Question Time in the British Parliament influence a pragma-dialectical understanding of that argumentative exchange. She noted that “the knowledge of the rules and conventions of a certain institution provides significant insights for understanding the arguer’s choice. The understanding is further enhanced by the knowledge of the role that a certain move fulfils in the context of critical testing” (2008, p. 384).

In each case, strategic maneuvering enters into the fray to help arguers navigate between the tensions of making reasonable arguments and still achieving their strategic goals. Overlapping audiences, the political consequences of making certain decisions, and the constraints that the forum places on the manner of argument presentation all create expectations for how one is to argue. These roles play an important, but not exclusive, place in measuring argument quality. Strategic maneuvering is in this sense a manifestation of rules and conventions of arguing as a contextual activity, akin to role fulfillment in BP debate. Recognizing and capitalizing on the various routes available to arguers, both for achieving desired outcomes and maintaining relations with other agents and decision makers, is a necessary component of public argumentation, and an explicit part of the BP judging paradigm.

We can take a second cue from an attempt to explicitly integrate rhetorical theory into competitive debate practice. In a *Contemporary Argumentation and Debate* forum on the prospects for invitational rhetoric (Foss and Griffin, 1995) as a reform platform for contest debating, Hobbs et. al. (2000) defended an approach to debate pedagogy rooted in collaboration with opponents as opposed to competition against them. Invitational rhetoric is skeptical of bids to change peoples' minds, and certainly of discourse that pits opposite arguments against one another where one must be declared superior over another. They favored instead an approach to judging debates based on which team better affirms feminist goals of collaboration with their counterparts. The relationships formed during the round become the decision criteria for the judges. "Critics could look for debaters who work together and affirm each other in an attempt to create a dialogue

intent on getting every perspective out in the open with the ultimate reward of creating understanding and making the best decision possible” (Hobbs et. al., 2000, p. 84). Makau (2000) echoed those views later in the forum. She asked critics to evaluate debaters based on the depth with which they explored the issue at hand, the ways that they created contexts of safety and value for their counterparts, and how well their performance contributed to the audience’s quality of deliberation on the subject.

In their rejection of invitational debate, Jarman and McDonald (2002) defended the role of technical, specialized debate as a vehicle for producing quality decisions. “Insofar as deliberation is concerned, though, problems are solved only when an argument prevails. That is to say, once one side has ‘won’ sufficient support for their cause then change can be undertaken” (Jarman and McDonald, 2002, p. 209). Since invitational debate does not lead to a hierarchicization of arguments (as that would violate feminist values of equity and safety), it does not lead to the selection of one policy outcome over another. According to Jarman and MacDonald, this picking between policies is necessary to adopt solutions to problems. From within the logic of a binary debate model, this makes sense. In the end, we must choose A or B, and debate is a tool to make that sort of decision.

But if we broadened our view of the ways debate operates, we may not be so locked into mutually exclusive outcomes as the hallmark of debate as a technique for making judgments. The coalition model provides a mechanism to resolve disputes by forging relationships with other actors in a policymaking context. Rather than choosing between zero-sum solutions, perhaps synthesis is actually the best remedy. Coalitions survive because disparate worldviews and political interests have found common cause,

and argumentation is needed to maintain that relationship. Making decisions within that context may be as much about finding common ground between competing arguments as about attacking their weaknesses. Decisions need not be made by one argument prevailing over another. They can be made by developing a new argument through compromise. Coalition argumentation embodies the latter approach. Reconceptualizing argumentation as the process of achieving this consensus, it looks more like BP's model of rival teams on the same side of the resolution than the purely adversarial argumentation of most US formats.

Surely, many policymaking contexts fall under the judicial model where rival teams of advocates compete for a binary outcome from an independent adjudicator. But many also fall under the coalition model, where the advocates themselves are the decision makers. In a legislature or parliament, hundreds of votes are available on any one motion. Those same votes will be sought after on numerous motions to follow. Problems are solved in the future by maintaining access to those votes, by creating a coalition that can survive disagreements and still come together on the next resolution.

I do not make this point to endorse the invitational critique of debate or persuasion. But, after the arrival of BP debate, we can no longer dismiss it on the grounds that debate *must* produce binary decisions. Ranking teams based on role fulfillment provides a more friendly adjudication approach to affirm the goals of invitational rhetoric. We can use this line of analysis to see the implications of basing a debate format on the judicial or coalition models. Binary formats tend to be bound by the ego-centric dynamic of one win-one loss. BP debate offers a more communal space for relationships

between debaters to be considered. Invitational rhetoric offers one version of what that relationship might look like, but a spectrum of possible answers to how relations are built between advocates, critics and topics are possible.

Strategic maneuvering takes a project that was initially looking for overarching rules of reasonability and rhetoricizes it. Invitational debate takes a technical and competitive enterprise and feminizes it. But, both show how roles played by advocates and the relationships between speakers can alter our understanding of argumentation, in debate and in the world.

The Centrality of Role Fulfillment

The rise of BP debate is fueled in part by dissatisfaction with the other available debate formats in the United States. Reasons for adopting BP vary, from the desire for internationalization, to accessibility for novices, to avoidance of what many consider the excesses of highly technical formats. But the striking popularity of BP debate internationally is also a measure of the quality of the format. The coalition model coupled with the burden of role fulfillment, when executed with skill, produces fair and deep examinations of topics through a wide variety of arguments. The skills students who learn BP develop are different, but no less valuable, than other debate formats.

While this essay has focused mainly on political argumentation, the coalition model is even more prevalent if we expand the scope of what we consider an argumentative forum. Most would describe a workplace patterned on the judicial model, where competing factions within the organization strive for a binary decision from an all-powerful decision maker,

as a nightmare. Working together toward a common goal, even while advancing competing arguments, better leverages talent and is especially good for maintaining a healthy organizational culture. Likewise, judicial argumentation in interpersonal relationships would be dysfunctional at best. Coalition building and relationship maintenance through argumentation is an important skill. It requires the ability to compromise as much as the ability to defeat an argument. It also requires friends and loved ones to consider the implications of their arguments, and the prospect that a short term victory may do irrevocable damage to future relationships.

To that end, the importance of coalition building in society at-large may encourage us to refocus on role fulfillment as BP practitioners. Debate handbooks tend to consider role fulfillment wholly as a mechanism for competitive success. Even Johnson framed it within a discussion of “winning debates.” As Llano (2012) noted, much of the written material concerning BP debate has been produced in the interests of informing students how to participate, driven in no small way by the lack of scholar/coaches in BP’s international iterations. The adoption of BP in the United States offers the chance for academics to observe how the format unfolds over time, and theorize role fulfillment both within debate and how it is exported to venues beyond the University. The multi-decade polarization of American political discourse is ripe for similar analysis. Even as the United States is not a parliamentary form of government, it is still plagued by the failure to find common ground between competing factions or to put coalition building above scoring personal political victories. Government shutdowns and gridlock are the product of the failure to fulfill one’s role as a legislator. Measuring an argument’s quality is in part a matter of understanding its impact

on the decision making process, and role fulfillment has significant potential as a heuristic for thinking such things through.

Role fulfillment deserves more development, more experimentation, and more consideration of its uniqueness in argument pedagogy. But, being too explicit about what that means may backfire. Adjudication cores like the 2015 WUDC team have taken more and more to outlining the standards they see for better persuasion in handbooks for competitors. While they do so in the interests of standardizing debate across numerous cultural and national conventions, there is a danger in the project. What it means to fulfill an argumentative role, as we have seen in this essay, is a context bound set of standards produced through discussion. Audiences, topics, and goals change over time. Organically, groups of adjudicators come to see certain argumentative practices as preferable to others, and that consensus is constantly subject to revision. As even the pragma-dialecticians know, the rules of reasonability exist in concert with the fleeting constraints of context. Writing down standards for arguments in the interests of furthering competition threatens to become the very set of rules that BP debate has in the past forcefully eschewed. This can be doubly dangerous if the standards of argumentation are frozen in amber from the perspective of elites within the activity. When cultural capital is available for distribution, debate standards will inevitably favor the privilege of those holding institutional power (Paroske, 2011).

Avoiding codification, and relying on the discussion produced by changing audiences over time to determine what role fulfillment really is, leads to more opaque and complex argumentation. But this is how real world argumentation works. One thing we can focus on is the

impact that format has on shaping how these roles are determined and met. Rowland (2013), after concluding that from the perspective of argument quality Obama won the first 2012 presidential debate, but that he was nonetheless perceived as the loser by journalists and voters looking at the politics of the event, argued for format changes. Rowland wanted to produce deeper exploration of the issues in a presidential debate by changing the rules of interaction among the participants to encourage clash. He pined for “sensibly presenting complex arguments” (p. 542). The “better debate” standard for role fulfillment seems a pretty good starting point to consider how the competing demands of argument quality and coalition building interact, and how formats can best provide a context for those interactions to lead to good decisions.

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